

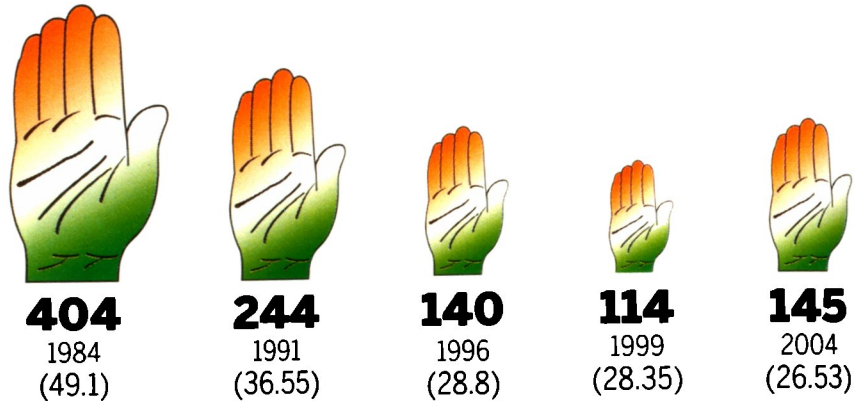
SHRINKING PARTIES

The two main contenders

CONGRESS

- S** Enjoys nationwide presence. In Rahul Gandhi, has a leader who will come in handy to help win the youth vote.
- W** Lacks depth to script victory alone. Up against leaders like Mulayam, Lalu and Pawar who are fiercely independent.
- O** In spite of mind games played by its partners, the UPA remains the preferred alliance for all its existing constituents.
- T** Hopes that parties like the JD(U) and AIADMK will join and the Left will back it if it becomes the single largest party.

The weakening Congress grip



Figures in brackets are vote share in per cent

THE GRAND OLD PARTY WAS THE ONLY PAN-INDIA OUTFIT BUT TODAY ITS STRENGTH COMES FROM SCATTERED POCKETS.

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IS THE NUMBER OF SEATS THAT THE SIX NATIONAL PARTIES WON IN THE 10TH LOK SABHA ELECTIONS HELD IN 1991.

Today, as the country is barely six weeks away from the General Elections, the Congress and BJP, the Big Two of Indian politics, are presided over by leaders for whom India continues to be a Great Incomprehension. In their distinctive ways, both of them are inheritors who squandered the wealth of tradition. Congress president Sonia Gandhi—still a desperate work in progress as Mrs G. Part Two—may be the most powerful woman in India, and Our Lady of Deliverance for those Congressmen who can't imagine an existence without the sheltering shadow of the Dynasty. That hereditary privilege is not translated into grassroots, pan-India power. She, along with son and heir apparent Rahul, marks the waning mystique of dynastic power. And on the right side of the political divide, the leader as a towering alternative to the ruling establishment exists only in his fantasy. L.K. Advani, the BJP's prime ministerial candidate and no longer Mr Number Two, would go to any extent—the gym or cyberspace—to convince the still unconvinced that youthful-

ness has nothing to do with biology. The most perseverant yatri of Indian politics may have come closer to the destination. His party, unfortunately, has not kept pace. It looks too weak—organisationally as well as ideologically—to take him to the place he always wanted to be. Remember, it was the party that brought a historic shift in Delhi. The leaders, in retrospect, didn't even realise the romance of the moment. The BJP is in an identity crisis and its managers have no formula for a revival. The space that rightfully belongs to the party is shrinking—or being taken over by others.

Sonia and Advani have certain things in common though. Both prefer the safety and secrecy of a kitchen cabinet consisting of non-political confidants and sycophants to inner-party democracy. They have created a party within the party. Both have strong personal favourites; and betrayers are never forgiven. Still, Advani at 81 wants to be different